



FinMango Report:
Financial Inclusion in Developing
Countries – Comparative Case
Study: Argentina & Brazil

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Executive Summary

- **What specific problem(s) is FinMango proposing to solve?**

- The problem FinMango is trying to solve is that of the lack of sustainable financial inclusion in Latin America.
- The report researches Brazil and Argentina as comparative case study to determine the main issues in the region, the current measures in place and which have been successful, and what problems have not yet been solved. This analysis then aims to explore market opportunities for the implementation of specific solutions by FinMango.
- The main target audience of our solutions will be middle and low-income individuals, with a greater focus on the latter who tend to currently be the most affected by financial exclusion.
- The main issues identified in the report by Finmango are:
 - High levels of financial illiteracy, caused by lack of incentives and programs available for lower income portions of the population:
 - In Argentina only 38% of the population showed a "high level of knowledge" (scores above 5.0 in a Central Bank survey) when it comes to financial literacy.
 - The country ranked 37th out of 39 economies surveyed by the OECD in terms of financial literacy.
 - Lack of partnerships between public and private sectors
 - Difficulty accessing credit and loans (particularly for lower income households)

- **What exactly do we plan to do to solve those problems?**

- FinMango's approach will be based on two solutions, which have been designed to go hand in hand in tackling the issues and promote further access to education and financing in poorer communities
- The first solution will be the development of an online curriculum regarding financial education, which will be translated into a digitized program that can be easily accessed by those in poorer communities. Upon completion of the program, individuals will be awarded with a certificate of completion provided by FinMango, which can be used to improve their credit rating
- The second solution is to bring low cost banks and micro financing and credit institutions to lower income people. This will be done through partnerships with financial institutions and fintechs¹ as well as inclusion of available institutions in financial education programs to raise awareness of online financial instruments that can help these individuals.
- Partnerships will also make the certificates provided in financial education programs serve as guarantees that individuals are financially literate, which will increase credit ratings and make credit more available for lower income people at lower interest.

¹ Partnerships are yet to be made

- **What are we doing different from competitors in our space? What are we doing better than competitors in our space (and perhaps totally new)?**
 - FinMango's financial education programs will not be for profit, meaning they will be accessible for lower income portions of the population.
 - Moreover, a digitized curriculum will increase the reach of the program and will facilitate access to people independent of age. In Brazil, financial education programs have recently been implemented in schools, and so are only accessible to upcoming generations. Moreover, poorer populations have a lower incidence of enrollment in school and less incentives to learn in Latin America, given they often start to work at younger ages to help household incomes.
 - FinMango's program provides incentives for people to complete education programs, and concomitant to this increases their credit rating. This encourages participation in the financial system. We are thus able to tackle two issues with a combined solution: financial literacy and access to credit, thus helping to solve the issue of sustainable financial education.

- **What is the timeline, and how do we measure success?**
 - Spring 2021
 - Build 3 digital short courses on financial education, and find partners to help with this
 - Design assessments for each course (homework and testing)
 - Develop a plan for remote proctoring and automated grading. Seek out partners for this effort
 - Begin talks with several financial institutions to seek a pathway to discounted borrowing rates for individuals completing our certification program
 - Fall 2021
 - Identify appropriate accrediting bodies for our certification program
 - Begin implementation of program in Brazilian cities
 - Find partnerships to advertise program and increase reach
 - Spring 2022
 - Aim to have at least 1000 people successfully complete the program and more signing up
 - Fall 2022
 - Begin expansion into other Latin American countries

Introduction

Financial inclusion is a key enabler to reducing poverty and improving the average standard of living. According to the World Bank, "financial inclusion means that individuals and businesses have access to useful and affordable financial products and services that meet their needs – transactions, payments, savings, credit, and insurance – delivered in a responsible and sustainable way." The process of greater inclusivity is propelled by increases in levels of financial education (financial literacy). Achieving higher levels of financial inclusion helps people secure financial services and products, such as fund transfer and payment services, insurance, loans, etc., at economical prices. Financial inclusion is grounded on the establishment of proper financial institutions to cater to the needs of all people, especially those with unfavored economic conditions who require financial instruments with proper education to grow. This report will explore the intricacies of achieving a more financially inclusive society, including the effects of financial illiteracy and potential programs and initiatives that could lead to improvements. Through the analysis of Argentina and Brazil as case studies, this report will build on the topic of financial inclusion and education.

Financial Inclusion Around the World

According to the World Bank's Global Findex, 1.7 billion adults worldwide lack access to basic financial services. This means they:

- **Don't have a secure place to save money;**
- **Don't have access to small loans or credit lines** and can fall prey to unscrupulous lenders;
- **Can't build a credit record;**
- **Have no way to receive money**—including customer payments or remittances from relatives working abroad;
- **Have no safe, reliable, and easy way to make payments**, such as to suppliers, schools, or doctors.

These issues are most acute among low-income families in developing countries. In several emerging economies, up to 80% of people are excluded from financial services, exacerbating their conditions and hampering their ability to escape poverty. This happens given that access to financial and social assets are key contributing factors to help youth make their own economic decisions. Providing young people with financial services, such as an appropriately structured loan for investments could be determining whether they are able to escape the precarious conditions instigated by an unfavorable economic environment. In developing countries, most people, especially women, lack access to financial services and if given access might be unable or discouraged to use them due to financial illiteracy, propagated by poor financial education.

Although less developed countries are affected the most, with over 50% of the population in developing countries not having a bank account, against 10% in rich and developed countries, the problem regarding lack of financial inclusion is ubiquitous. It also affects developed countries and is even a major social and economic concern. Many people in

developed countries still suffer from bank indebtedness, the casualization of low-income workers, but also the closure of post offices and banks in some areas which contribute to separate a portion of the population from access to banking services. This demonstrates how the lack of financial inclusion remains a problem for every economy in the world.

When seeking financial inclusion, it is essential to seek a sustainable one. Sustainability in terms of financial inclusion not only ensures that the next generation will have as much and preferably more access to financial services than the previous one but means that besides having access to financial instruments, people will have the necessary education to use them. Sustainable financial inclusion is potentially one of the world's main goals, given the UN considers it pivotal towards attaining the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). According to MDPI, "the goal of **sustainable financial inclusion** is to provide **financial** support to vulnerable groups based on equal opportunities, help them reduce poverty, thereby reducing social inequality and achieving stable economic growth" (MDPI, 2019). **All in all sustainable financial inclusion refers to individuals not only having access to financial instruments but also being able to use them properly.**

Financial inclusion is positioned prominently as an enabler of other developmental goals in the 2030 Sustainable Development Goals, where it is featured as a target in eight of the seventeen goals. These include:

- **SDG1:** on eradicating poverty;
- **SDG 2:** on ending hunger, achieving food security, and promoting sustainable agriculture;
- **SDG 3:** on profiting health and well-being;
- **SDG 5:** on achieving gender equality and economic empowerment of women;
- **SDG 8:** on promoting economic growth and jobs;
- **SDG 9:** on supporting industry, innovation, and infrastructure;
- **SDG 10:** on reducing inequality.

Additionally, according to the UNCDF², "in SDG 17 on strengthening the means of implementation, there is an implicit role for greater financial inclusion through greater savings mobilization for investment and consumption that can spur growth" (UNCDF, 2020).

The importance of financial inclusion in the SDGs highlights how important of a topic it is. Financial inclusion, fomented by financial education, is crucial for economic development as explored in the following section and the lack of it engenders several issues, as explored in the following sections.

Why is financial inclusion important?

The lack of financial inclusion can have dire consequences both microeconomically and macroeconomically. As argued by Jeffrey Leopold, current chair of the Virginia Board of

² UN Capital Development Fund

Financial Education, financial education is such an important topic that it could have mitigated or even potentially prevented the 2008 financial crisis. Leopold believes that the right financial instruments aided by the proper knowledge of how to use them towards one's economic leverage could have prevented the crisis from happening. Financial inclusion is considered crucial towards a more economically sustainable society by financially empowering individuals. In research conducted by Chuc, Le, and Taghizadeh-Hesary, they argue,

"formal financial inclusion begins with having a deposit or transaction account, at a bank or other financial service provider, for the purpose of making and receiving payments as well as storing or saving money (Demirguc-Kunt, Klapper, & Singer, 2017). At a later stage, financial inclusion also involves access to appropriate credit from formal financial institutions, in addition to the use of insurance products that enable people to alleviate financial risks such as fire, flood, or crop damage (Demirguc-Kunt et al., 2017).

Furthermore, access to accounts through financial inclusion increased savings among farmers, leading to greater agricultural output and household spending (Demirguc-Kunt et al., 2017). This particularly matters for those people who live in the poorest households in rural areas. In this regard, financial inclusion helps reduce poverty and inequality." (Le, Chuc, & Taghizadeh-Hesary, 2019)

Essentially speaking, access to different financial services help advance business endeavors for people, especially for lower-income households who have less capital to spend. Access to credit, for example, is one of the main propellers of businesses. Economic theory suggests that there is an opportunity cost in financing your business with only stockholder equity. Access to credit allows for debt financing, which allows you to invest money from personal investors in growing the business. Debt is considered leverage and is pivotal in business and overall finances. Ergo, access to financial services might be a determining factor in whether people will be able to finance their projects or not. For low-income households, who usually have a high marginal propensity to consume, meaning that a greater percentage of their income is used towards consumption of necessary goods and services, there is barely any money for them to save. With access to services, they have institutions that help them save money and finance them to help them change their situation. The traditional source of funds for emerging market poor was from local banks, who often didn't want to lend to them because they were such high risk or the loan was too small. Equity was not even a possibility unless it was entirely provided by the individual. **Ergo, there is a need for a better system of credit, which will provide low income households with leverage to be able to participate in the economy and become financially included.**

There is an important consideration, however. Financial Inclusion differs from sustainable financial inclusion, as discussed before. If people have more access to services but are unable to properly take advantage of them due to financial illiteracy, then this might actually be more problematic than beneficial.

For example, financing through the acquisition of loans means that people will be temporarily in debt. While debt might provide leverage for firms, if unsustainable, it might create a burden on people. Financially illiterate individuals do not have the proper education to analyze a situation before acquiring loans. This might lead to debt spirals where individuals see ever

increasing levels of debt. A lack of financial education, implies in this case that even if people have access to credit, if taken irresponsibly, then this increased access to financial services might actually be more detrimental than beneficial. In an interview with Gunar Viana, Founder & Head of Investments at TRAAD, a fintech specialized in financial education, he explains that the lack of financial education leads to poor economic decisions. "You [often] see people reach the limit of the overdraft facility or of their credit cards to buy a new cell phone and that is when you realize they have no notion of what they are doing; no notions of finance." Using credit to buy something unnecessary, such as the newest model of a particular phone, is one of the examples used by Mr. Viana as how financial inclusion must be sustainable through proper financial education, because, if not, then it might actually exacerbate one's economic condition. Furthermore, another example of how financial inclusion must accompany proper education – if not it is unsustainable – is that financial illiteracy creates an environment that is prone to dependencies between a financial service provider and the customer.

According to Lars Greiner, a senior consultant at HPC with extensive experience working in Africa, "you struggle to find a banking menu in [African] countries, it is just something they [economically disadvantaged people] simply don't know. They don't trust banks because they do not know them. In the past there have been schemes that steal their money and don't give them back to them. So it is a case where they need to get to know, through education, but also develop trust in these organizations." Financial service providers can easily take advantage of customers who lack proper financial education, which engenders a state of dependency for the customer, meaning they can easily charge high interest rates, that although would normally constitute as usury³, they could get away with this due to the financial illiteracy of an individual. They are, therefore, indebted in large amounts and dependent on financial services to relieve them of their debts. Ergo, without education, financial inclusion might make people prone to extortion from less reliable or informal institutions.

These problems are recurring in developing economies, especially those in Africa and Latin America. They serve as examples of how sustainable financial inclusion is needed, and how they might be crucial in economic development. To establish sustainable financial inclusion, it is important to follow a customer journey.

Customer Journey

The journey of financial inclusion includes many steps and hurdles along the way. The process is a long and difficult one, and one that requires creativity and flexibility, but it can truly change lives and bring a whole society out of poverty. The process breaks down into four main steps, which are outlined below, along with some common challenges that may be encountered.

³ It is also likely that high rates are justifiable due to 1) a high proportion of fixed costs around a very small loan, and 2) exceptionally high risk around the individual due to the risky economy of their country AND the financial illiteracy of the individual.

Step 1: Establishing financial institutions and products that allow for financial inclusion.

Before underprivileged people can contribute to a society's economy and finances, and before they can even learn the basics, they have to have access to the financial products and services that are necessary to achieve that. In 2017, Brazil and Argentina, the two countries this report focuses on, claimed that 32% and 11% of the population without a financial institution account, respectively, explained their lack of account by financial institutions being "too far away". The two countries also reported that 57% and 43% of the population without a financial institution account, respectively, explain their lack of account because financial institutions are too expensive. A lack of convenient access to the necessary financial resources are a significant hindrance to financial inclusion. Even if the financial institutions are accessible and affordable, the people that need them the most, are often not aware of their presence or significance.

Step 2: Make these financial institutions and products accessible to everyone

Once the necessary resources are available, they must be made accessible to everyone, in a way that encourages some of the most financially excluded individuals to take advantage of these resources that are completely unfamiliar to them. Logistical problems include lack of necessary documentation, which affected 30% of the Argentina population without a financial institution account and 19% of the Brazil population without a financial institution account in 2017, religious reasons, which affected 2% of both Argentina and Brazil populations without a financial institutions account in 2017. The most common issue standing in the way of financially excluded individuals and an account at a financial institution is a lack of sufficient funds. This problem affects 59% of the Argentina and 58% of the Brazil population without a financial institution account in 2017. There are also cultural obstacles, such as a lack of trust or inclination to take advantage of the financial products and services. For example, in Argentina and Brazil, 25% of both populations without a financial institution account give "lack of trust in financial institutions" as their primary reason why. Therefore, this step of the process must give individuals with low funds, missing documentation, religious obstacles, and distrust in financial institutions a way and a reason to participate in financial activities. Every society has their own cultures and attitudes, so it is therefore crucial to get bottom-up information on how to help people and maximize their potential.

Step 3: Give people the proper financial education so they know how to use financial institutions and products

Many people in low income countries, such as Argentina, may have the ability and will to take advantage of financial resources, but lack the knowledge of how to do this. Many may need basic general education before they can even start on financial education, such as the ability to read or an understanding of what large numbers represent. For example, in Guatemala and Nicaragua, almost 1 out of 5 people over the age of 15 cannot read or write. The process of financial education can be a long process for certain individuals and may require personal diligence and motivation. Therefore, this step will also require determining how to incentivize individuals to learn and continue to use what they learn in the long run.

Step 4: Implement long-term sustainable solutions

A key identification in the finclusion world has been that financial education and financial inclusion is meaningless without an element of sustainability. In order to optimize sustainability and minimize the drop-off rate of financial participation after supervision and guidance is discontinued, individuals must be intrinsically motivated to further or maintain their financial inclusion. Individuals must understand the rewards of consistent participation and the consequences of the alternative. Financial processes must also be simple and engaging enough that customers have positive interactions with the products and services (positive interactions are determined by ease of use of financial products). According to the Stanford Social Intervention Review, 4 conditions are necessary for ideal long-term financial processes: “enforceability of contracts, an absence of transaction costs, perfect competition, and fully rational consumer behavior.” While these outcomes are only theoretical, any shift toward these ideals will yield economic benefits

Main Body

The focus of this paper will be on Latin America. The case studies will use the region to demonstrate their issues regarding financial inclusion and the current measure being put into place to tackle these issues before concluding with measures that could be beneficial for developing countries in improving their financial inclusion and literacy rates. These measures proposed will be focused on solving the issues explored in the case studies and are all measures that require the help and initiative of fintechs such as FinMango to be properly implemented.

Latin America

Latin America has some of the world's leading emerging markets. In the last decade, it has shown favorable economic growth rates. According to a report released by the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD), "The region displayed noteworthy resilience in the recent global economic crisis, performing well relative to economies elsewhere in the world and reversing the immediate downturn fairly quickly (OECD 2011; OECD/Economic Commission for Latin America and the Caribbean, 2012)." The financial systems in multiple Latin American countries have been able to withstand the impacts of economic crises particularly well, being able to sustain the quality of loans, solvency, and market liquidity. Their efforts have been successful as a result of improved prudential regulation and supervision already in place at the onset of the crisis (OECD 2011). Consequently, Governments have been able to formulate generally favorable policies towards economic advancements and sustainable development goals.

Despite recent economic improvements, the OECD still remarks that Latin America is still considered a vastly unequal area of the world. The United Nations Development Programme reports it as the most unequal region in the world, with a large portion of the region's wealth accumulated in the hands of a select few. GDP per capita is still relatively low, indicating high levels of poverty across the region. This is further verified by a relatively high human poverty index score, fueled by the fact that as of recent as 2017, around 30.2% (roughly

182 million people) lived in poverty (CEPAL, 2017). When analyzing the Gini Coefficient of Latin American countries, the numbers tend to be considerably high. According to data from the world bank, the region mostly averages above 45 (from the data collected from 11 countries in Latin America in 2018, the average coefficient was 46.36), whereas, OECD countries are located, on average, at approximately 33. The disparity between Latin American countries and OECD countries indicates how the levels of economic inequality in the region are comparatively high and how alarming the numbers are.

One of the main issues for Latin America is that the low rates of financial literacy further exacerbate this inequality and obstruct improvements in financial inclusion, as explained at the beginning of the report. Latin America is, therefore, quite an interesting case study since, **while it is one of the world's leading emerging markets, with commendable economic growth rates, one must pose the question of whether these growth rates are sustainable in the long run, given that they suffer from high levels of economic inequality fomented by lack of financial inclusion. Moreover, similar language and cultural ties across the entire region provide a huge potential benefit. The development of successful strategies in any one location can likely be extended across the entire region.**

In recently released reports by the OECD in regards to financial inclusion in Latin America, they state that "Financial education can empower individuals and allow them to better manage personal and household finances and resources. In Latin America, this applies both to the emerging or consolidating middle classes (The **middle class** is identified as people living in households with **income** per capita between \$10 and \$50 per day, adjusted for purchasing power parity according to researcher and CDG co-founder, Nancy Birdsall), who might need to better manage their finances over longer time horizons, and to the poor and to the financially excluded." Macroeconomic stability has allowed the government to focus on public policies that build on the complementarities between financial education, inclusion, and the development of social capital. Recently, several countries in Latin America have recognized the importance of financial inclusion towards long term sustained economic growth and have, subsequently, started to implement policies to increase financial education – a propeller of greater financial inclusion, as mentioned before.

One of the main problems in improving financial inclusion, however, is the accessibility to financial education programmes. The region has seen significant improvements in terms of access to the formal education system. Between 1990 and 2006 the region faced a substantial increase in the number of young people having completed secondary education, from 27% to 51%. However, inequalities persist, with the first income quintile (lowest income) displaying around a quarter of the percentage found in the last quintile (highest income) (OECD, 2013). This lack of access to financial education hampers advances in financial inclusion, which is why new policies are being enacted to better focus on the lower-income portion of the population.

Latin America is, therefore, an interesting case study for financial inclusion considering that:

- The region is known for having some of the world's leading emerging markets, with substantial improvements in economic growth, but limited due to political instability, which affects the ability of governments to implement policies that could favor financial inclusion.
- It is also considered the world's most unequal region when it comes to wealth distribution, leading to a large population of people in poverty, which is historically considered the most affected group when it comes to financial inclusion
- Lack of access to financial education for the majority of the low-income population exacerbates low levels of financial inclusion
- Economic growth with a lack of financial inclusion might culminate in greater income inequality. Recent policies have been implemented, and therefore serves as a case study for how different policies and initiatives impact financial inclusion despite the plethora of obstacles towards it.

Ergo, this report will mainly address financial inclusion in Latin America, with a focus on the comparison between two particular case studies that represent some of the regions largest and historically most important economies in the region, who suffer from substantial levels of inequality yet high levels of economic activity: Argentina and Brazil. Argentina and Brazil serve as interesting grounds for comparison given they are the two largest economies in Latin America outside the OECD. Historically, they have had both moments of rivalry and cooperation, signing bilateral trade agreements in recent years and establishing commercial partnerships in their key industries. Brazil is Argentinas biggest exporter and importer. Their economies are considerably intertwined. As explained by Carlos Eduardo Abijaodi, Director of the Brazilian National Industry Federation of Industrial Development, "Argentina has always been considered a crucial partner for the Brazilian industry, not only because of the proximity, but also because of how complementary our economies are and our partnership in Mercosur."⁴ Thus, not only are they interesting representatives of the problem and advances in financial inclusion in Latin America, but their proximity and importance allows us to derive fundamental comparisons.

Case Study: Argentina

Why Argentina?

When it comes to financial inclusion in Latin America, an interesting case study is Argentina. Argentina is currently one of Latin America's largest economies, with the third-highest GDP and second-largest total area. Despite its economic prowess in terms of output, financial exclusion is an overwhelming issue, and a majority of the population are financially excluded to

⁴<https://epocanegocios.globo.com/Economia/noticia/2019/12/com-economias-dependentes-brasil-e-argentina-tentam-superar-desconfiancas.html>

some extent. Its capital, Buenos Aires, is in the , according to Z/Yen, a private research institute that constructed an index for financial center rating in 2019, in which a multitude of factors – including but not limited to the business environment, human capital, taxation, infrastructure, and financial sector development – are integrated. While one could mistakenly assume that, given Argentina's substantial financial output compared to other Latin American countries, their economic environment is a propeller for financial inclusion and literacy rates, the truth is Argentina lags behind other Latin American countries when it comes to financial inclusion.

In 2017 the Argentinian Central Bank (BCRA) conducted the Financial Capacity Measurement Survey and presented it under the title, “Where Are We and Where Are We Headed?” The research was conducted by the Senior Specialist in Productive and Financial Development at CAF (the Development Bank of Latin America), Diana Mejía, and the head of Financial Literacy and Institutional and Social Responsibility of the BCRA, Mariano Iglesias. It was prepared based on the methodology developed by the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD). “According to the survey, knowledge about financial products is moderate nationwide: only 8 products or services are known by more than 50% of respondents. Furthermore, 39% of adults said they did not hold any financial product, while the most commonly owned products are debit cards (42%), credit cards (37%), and savings funds (29%).” (CAF, 2017) The results of the survey culminated in Argentina being given a score of 11.5 out of 21 when it comes to financial inclusion, with the nation ranking 37th out of 39 surveyed economies. Argentina also ranks lowest among the six countries of the region also surveyed by CAF (Argentina, Bolivia, Chile, Colombia, Ecuador, and Peru), both in financial literacy and in behavior and attitude.

Argentina's poor performance in 2017 is not befitting of their levels of economic output, given that their ranking, as evaluated by the CAF, is lower than most of the other countries in Latin America, even though they stand as the third-largest economy in the region. In 2017, Argentina presented its National Strategy for Financial Inclusion. The program was supported by the Inter-American Development Bank (IDB). According to IDB, “Argentina's National Strategy will improve household and corporate access to the formal financial system, increase the use of financial services and means of payment, and promote the availability of digital financial services. It will also foster Micro and Small Enterprises' access to lending in sustainable terms. Its main beneficiaries will be poor and vulnerable segments of the population with no current access to the financial system, other sectors whose informal source of income precludes them from having adequate access to financial services, and Micro and Small Enterprises.” Despite the implementation of the program, financial inclusion in Argentina remains subpar. According to research conducted by the Central Bank of Argentina (BCRA), roughly 1 in 2 adults or 51% have a form of debt registered in the financial system. According to their research, “the most common [type of debt] was bank credit cards with 32 percent of adults having at least one debt of this type (Chart 2), followed by personal loans at 22 percent. Both figures greatly overshadow mortgage loans at 0.8 percent.” Thus, while they have implemented programs to improve financial inclusion, they are yet to see significant improvements. Their recent endeavors to improve financial literacy and inclusion mean that Argentina has been actively looking towards improving the current situation. **The reason the program has not yet**

seen the desired outcomes rests in the fact that Argentina has been recently going through political and economic turmoil, which hampers the effects of programmes aimed at aiding small enterprises to obtain loans due to greater loan default chances because of economic uncertainty and already growing debt.

Problems faced by Argentina

Argentina exhibits a generally low level of financial literacy and money management. According to a 2017 survey conducted by the Central Bank of Argentina to measure financial capability, only slightly more than half of argentinians have a budget (55%) and from these, 78% have a very general plan while only 19% have precise and thorough budgets. Within those who have a budget, 43% will follow it while 52% will occasionally follow it. Only 31% of those surveyed could cover unexpected expenses that equal a monthly salary without the need of credit, loans, or help from family and friends.

The survey also assigned overall scores to the country's financial knowledge, financial behavior and financial attitude. These scores were calculated based on carefully selected questions, for which a correct answer was assigned the score of 1 and an incorrect answer was assigned the score of 0. For financial knowledge, a score of 4.0 is below the level of reference and a score of 5.0 is considered high. Only 38% of the Argentinian population show a high level of knowledge. This score is relatively low at an international level, being ranked 31 out of 39 countries. It has been observed that the financial knowledge index is greater when salary and level of education attained are high. Nonetheless, half of the population with higher education lacks the basic knowledge to access and utilize the financial products and services available in the market.

The financial behavior indicator is constructed as a combination of 8 questions that reference the tendency and utilization of a loan, the management of the financial resources, behavior related to saving and the way of selecting financial products. 27% of those surveyed present a high level in financial behavior. This scenario leaves Argentina ranking 36 out of 39 countries in relation to financial behavior.

The national financial attitude score of 2.9 is almost at the reference level/score of 3.0, which implies an attitude of planning in the long run. In the majority of the populated groups more than 40% of those surveyed obtained high scores. In this case, just like in the financial knowledge indicator Argentina is ranked 31 out of 39 countries.

Argentina has a financial education score of 11.5 which ranks Argentina 37 out of 39 countries that apply to this survey and for those that have available, accessible and comparable information. This is below the average of the OECD (13.7) and G20 (12.7) countries.

At a regional level, once the methodology corrections have been made so that the indicators are comparable, the aggregate indicator of financial education in Argentina is 12 which locates in 6th (last) within the Latin American countries that count on the results of the CAF survey (Bolivia, Chila, Colombia, Ecuador y Perú).

Measures in place to combat financial illiteracy

The problem of financial illiteracy is becoming more acknowledged by national governments and global organizations. There are several measures in place that attempt to address and help solve the issue broadly, and they all take a slightly different approach. Eainversores is an online educational community that attempts to attack the problem by teaching people about the investment side of financing. The online courses teach people how to invest in stocks, public securities, corporate bonds, options and financial futures at the beginner level. Global Money Week is an annual financial awareness campaign that focuses on inspiring children and young people to learn about money matters, livelihoods and entrepreneurship. In 2019, the campaign in Argentina reached 7,188 people directly and 591,998 indirectly. The Argentinian national government has also developed a “presidency’s financial inclusion agenda” which includes action plans and key policies to allow more Argentine residents the ability to participate in financial processes. The Argentine government has also cooperated with the OECD to take advantage of digitization and outlined a specific course of action to improve financial literacy through policies and digital products.*

Case Study 2: Comparing Brazil to Argentina

Why Brazil?

Brazil has the highest GDP amongst Latin-American and Caribbean countries, with Argentina having the 3rd highest GDP in the same region, and an even higher GDP per capita than Brazil. However, there seems to be a significant discrepancy between the two countries in terms of financial literacy and inclusion. Based on research conducted by the Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD), 69% of Brazilian households located in large cities have at least one bank account, while only 44% of Argentinian households in large cities have an account.

In addition, according to the (OECD), Brazil also has a fully implemented National Strategy in terms of financial education, which is a rarity in many other Latin-American countries. This strategy, called the *Estrategia Nacional de Educacao Financeira* (ENEF), is focused on empowering the middle-class and educating lower-income families on financial education basics. This strategy came after successful efforts on Brazil’s part to lift many families out of poverty and to build and sustain a successful middle class. This plan seeks to maintain and continue these efforts. Argentina, however, does not have such an established program and in comparison falls behind in terms of its financial literacy and education. In a study conducted by the CAF Development Bank of Argentina, Argentina ranks last in financial education amongst other countries in the Latin-American region surveyed, such as Colombia, Peru, Chile, Ecuador, and Bolivia. Argentina also has a financial literacy score of 11.5, and ranked 37th out of 39 economies surveyed for their financial literacy amongst citizens.

Despite the relative similarities of their GDP and economic size, Brazil far outperforms Argentina in terms of financial literacy and inclusion. Comparing both countries side-by-side will

allow greater analysis into the steps Brazil takes towards comprehensive and widespread education that can be implemented in Argentina, as well as look into factors from Brazil that could potentially positively impact Argentina's financial literacy and inclusion rates.

Problems faced by Brazil

Brazilian people have not developed a financial literacy culture after facing high inflation for several decades with January 1987 to April 1990 being the worst time period.¹ Since the 1990s, the Central Bank of Brazil has tried to increase access to financial services, and as of 2010, correspondent outlets exist in all of Brazil's municipalities, in addition to credit cooperatives in 40% of municipalities.² In more than 800 schools in six states from 2010 to 2011, a financial education pilot program was implemented and results showed that students successfully developed a greater tendency to save their money.³

Despite this progress, results from the Programme for International Student Assessment (PISA) financial literacy assessment in 2015 indicated that nearly 53% students in Brazil were performing below the baseline level of proficiency, compared to the 22% on average across the 10 participating OECD countries.⁴ Only 2.6% of students in Brazil are top performers in financial literacy with Level 5 proficiency, meaning they can analyze complex financial products and solve unique financial problems. This engenders a microfinance problem where Brazilians with access to financial instruments are unable to use them and might end up in debt due to improper use of loans, as argued by Mr. Gunnar Viana.

Furthermore, adults in Brazil are especially vulnerable to adverse economic conditions because of high unemployment rates and a nonexistent welfare state to serve as a safety net. Individual participation in the formal financial system to provide a more secure environment is lacking in Brazil. From a 2017 survey led by BBVA, a mere 15% of Brazilian adults saved money with a financial institution during the past 12 months. Informal financial tools were most often used by adults, including asking friends and family for money or taking on extra jobs. The main issue with using informal financial instruments has to do with these options being much more unreliable than taking out a loan or using a credit card for a cash advance. These conditions result in the majority of Brazil's population suffering from financial vulnerability, especially women, young adults, and the elderly.

Measures in place to combat financial illiteracy

Brazil has one of the most robust and comprehensive financial literacy strategies in the Latin-American/Caribbean region, with the government playing an active role in its implementation. Brazil's national strategy, called ENEF (Estratégia Nacional de Educação Financeira) is driven by Brazil's recent economic growth and its desire to grow and consolidate its rising middle class. Another important driver is Brazil's research on unsustainable finances in many Brazilian households, with high consumption and low savings. The ENEF is also focused greatly on investment, with savings, credit, and investment being key factors in Brazil's continued economic growth as identified by the IMF in 2012. This strategy specifically targets

low to middle income families with significantly lower access to financial resources and proper financial education, such as families eligible for federal transfer payments. The implementation of a financial education curriculum and program in schools allows for an early start in financial literacy for many Brazilians. The Brazilian government also had a specifically established Working Group during its developing stage to oversee the implementation of the ENEF, which evaluates funding, goals, and monitoring in terms of widespread strategy implementation.

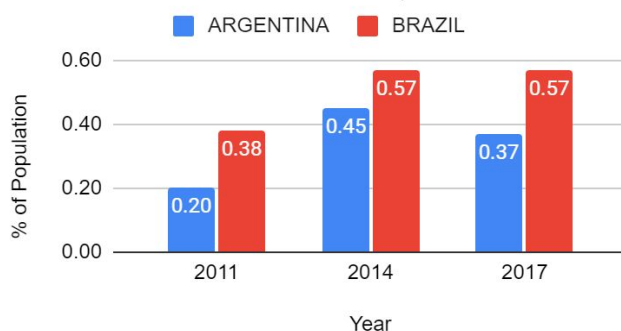
Public and private sector collaboration also plays an important role in widespread reach of financial education and ENEF. Currently, the strategy is under the responsibility of a governmental organization called CONEF, composed of government representatives from the Ministries of Justice, Finance, Education, and Social Security, as well as private sector representatives from industries such as capital markets, stocks and investments, and insurance. Many private stakeholders were also involved in the strategy's development phases, detailing certain chapters of the strategy during the design process of ENEF and establishing the National Association for Financial Education to assist in government efforts to spread financial literacy.

Comparing Recent Progress

When comparing progress made over this past decade using data from the world bank available from three in three years, a clear distinction between both countries can be made in their path towards financial inclusion and some similarities can also be found.

In regards to financial institution accounts, Brazil saw a significant increase at the start of the decade, as the rate of accounts for the poorest 40% grew from 0.38 to 0.57. The problem for Brazil was that this number remained stagnant, indicating that further advances to increase financial inclusion failed to reach the desired outcome. Perhaps this was fomented by the financial crisis faced by Brazil mid-2010s and ended up hampering efforts made by the country to improve. For Argentina it was even worse, given that they faced a setback, given the rate fell by the end of the decade after improvements in 2014.

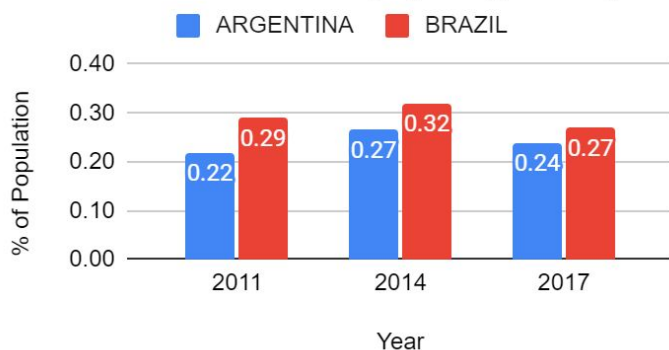
Financial Institution Account, Poorest 40%



A similar situation was seen in regards to credit card ownership. Ownership of credit cards saw significant decreases in both Brazil and Argentina, despite increases at the start of

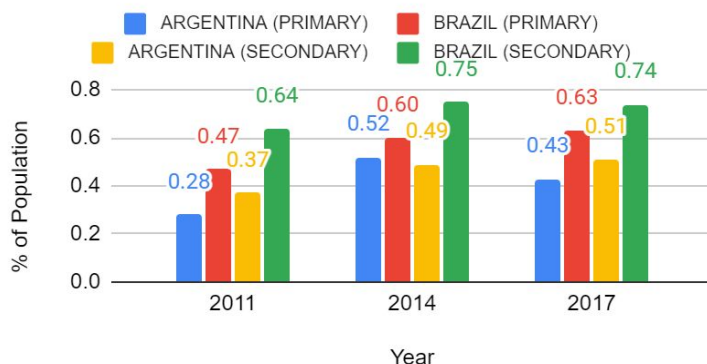
the decade. For Brazil, 2017 levels were even lower than 2011, whereas in Argentina they remained higher, but also saw a fall in comparison to 2014. Decreases in ownerships of credit cards is a very significant illustration of financial inclusion in a country. While several explanatory variables may be attributed to this cause, the trend could be a result of lower access to credit, lower credit scores, or the hesitation from the population of acquiring credit cards due to high interest rates. There are several problems that coil lead to this trend and they are portraits of low financial inclusion in these countries.

Credit card ownership (% age 15+)



When dividing financial inclusion based on social stratification, a clear issue can be observed. Education levels seem to be differentials in financial inclusion. For both countries, the percentage of people with secondary education that hold financial accounts is significantly higher than those with primary education. When looking at the progress made by both countries, in Brazil, policies seem to have been successful towards improving financial inclusion for people with no secondary education, whereas in Argentina, while in 2014 people with only primary education seemed to have more access to financial accounts than people with secondary education, in 2017, the percentage of people with primary education or less that had financial accounts fell drastically. Policies were unable to keep the numbers up. While in Brazil, the percentage of people with secondary education or more with financial accounts decreased by a meager 0.01 percentual points from 2014 to 2017, in Argentina, they increased by 0.02. What these numbers show is that, Argentina's policies in the early 2010s seemed to have better effects on highly educated people, whereas Brazil's policies seemed to have greater effect on less educated people.

Financial Account Holders: Primary Education or Less vs Secondary Education or More

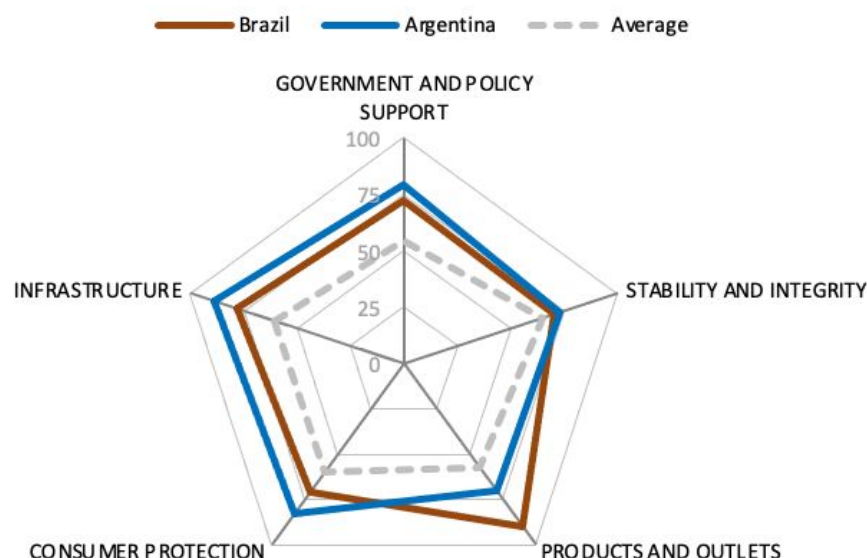


What we can conclude from these trends is that both countries still have to improve their numbers regarding financial inclusion. However, based on the last set of data, it seems like the programmes in place in both countries could be used as examples for each other. Brazil's apparent success in improving financial accounts holding for people with lower levels of education could be seen as an example for Argentina, while Argentina's success with people with secondary education could also be interpreted as an illustration of successful policies that might require higher levels of financial literacy to be effective but that could be implemented in Brazil. **The reason for this is probably due to the economic environment in both countries and how favorable it is to financial inclusion and institutions, as analyzed in the following section.**

Current Comparison

For a current comparison, to synthesize what has led to the different results in financial inclusion levels in both Argentina and Brazil, this section will aim to analyze the environment of financial inclusion based on the scores given by *The Economist Intelligence Unit*. Interestingly, despite recent trends in the decade of 2010s, Argentina still ranks higher than Brazil in terms of favorability of the environment towards financial inclusion. The ranking is based on government and policy support, stability and integrity, products and outlets, consumer protection and infrastructure. The graph below, taken from *The Economist* research in 2020, illustrates the

difference between both countries.



Argentina seems to be ahead Brazil in almost every category, except for one: products and outlets. When looking at more micro indicators, Argentina scores higher in promotion of literacy and capability (83 points versus Brazil's 67⁵) higher at broad strategies for financial inclusion (67 versus 58) and even higher customer due diligence (100 versus 25). **With Argentina's superiority in more categories, it is quite interesting that they rank below Brazil in levels of financial inclusion. Their environment seems slightly more propense for financial inclusion based on The Economist's analysis yet for some reason they are unable to translate this into actual higher levels of financial inclusion.** The reason for this goes back to the arguments made by Mr. Cordova and the policies aimed at the poorest population in both countries as explored in a [previous section](#). Once again, according to Mr. Cordova, Argentina's business environment is not as friendly. In fact, one of the few categories where Brazil scores higher than Argentina is incentives for digitisation, scoring a 91 vs Argentina's 89. Brazil has more incentives for private institutions and digitisation, which is a key proponent in increasing the reach of financial instruments to more scattered parts of the population. While the difference in score is particularly low, Brazil is the largest fintech ecosystem in Latin America (Finnovista, 2018), which could be a reason as to why it still leads over Argentina in financial inclusion, despite Argentina having a more friendly financial inclusion environment.

Moreover, the biggest difference between both is their score in credit portfolios for middle and low-income customers, where Brazil overcomes Argentina by a difference of 75 points, with the former scoring 100 and the latter only 25. This could also be seen as a significant difference. Access to credit is a recurring topic in financial inclusion, and it is one of the main proponents for individuals in getting out of situations of poverty. As stated in a report conducted by the *World Bank*, **"Incorporating microcredit data in formal credit reporting**

⁵ Rankings out of 100

systems and consumer education can facilitate financial inclusion, particularly for low income populations." Credit is determinant in people being able to obtain leverage to pursue economic objectives and access financial services.

The disparity in these numbers can be seen as a major reason as to why Argentina ranks higher than Brazil in friendliness of environment, but is unable to translate this financial inclusion friendly environment into concrete results: **it lags far behind in access to credit and how business friendly is its environment.** For this reason, when discussing potential solutions, one of our main focuses will be improving access to credit and improving fintech participation in the road towards greater financial education and inclusion.

Synthesis

Based on the issues seen in both countries and through an analysis of what they need to improve and what measure they have already implemented, we have shortlisted possible solutions that could be implemented to improve levels of financial inclusion in a sustainable way. The main issues we observed through are analysis and the ones we decided to focus on were **access to credit** and **financial education**. The former ensures greater financial inclusion while the latter ensures it is sustainable. The following section discusses these solutions based on policies already implemented and the opinions of different interviewed experts in their respective countries. It will also expand on how FinMango might act and detail what its potential role would be in enacting these solutions.

Possible solutions

- **Financial education**

One solution to the problem of lack of financial inclusion is providing people with proper financial education. As argued by Mr.Viana, "[one of the] problems with sustainable financial inclusion in Brazil is that even if people are included in financial systems, they are unable to make good use of them. There are no incentives for them to seek their own inclusion or the necessary education to do that. The topic of access to credit, for example, is one that engenders a lot of debate. (...) People are unbanked, without access to credit. Offering credit without a financial education is very bad for people's lives. **You have to fight the microcredit culture aimed at consumption, if not, then it creates a culture of accumulating debt due to inconsequential consumerism.** Credit has to be given along with support for people to plan financially so as not to get into debt, and if this happens, then people will slowly start to get more involved in the financial system. People will have money to save, will create bank accounts, will participate in the financial system, and inclusion will improve." Essentially, in countries like Brazil, where financial education lags behind, people might be discouraged to use financial services. As argued by philosopher Juliet Schor in *New Policies of Consumption*, society is currently undergoing a process of a new consumerism, where social pressures encourage the consumption of unnecessary goods. When combined with exorbitant rates and lack of financial

education, this new consumerism is disastrous for the financial health of an individual and discourages participation in financial services. Mr.Viana sees this as an issue as financially illiterate individuals are taking loans to purchase new and expensive phones, new TVs, and other unnecessary goods that have cheaper options, but due to this culture of consumption, seem less attractive. As individuals are uneducated in finance they will get these loans at high-interest rates, regardless of whether they will be able to repay them or not. As a result, they remain in debt and have less money to save as well as less confidence to use financial services. In general, people will not use what they do not know, especially if they perceive it as a risky investment. Ergo, Mr.Viana argues that financial education is vital towards encouraging individuals to use financial services, which would positively impact financial inclusion rates, as well as promote sustainability.

An important step towards financial literacy is the establishment of a comprehensive financial education curriculum and implementation plan. Brazil's strategy for financial education, referred to as ENEF (Estrategia Nacional de Educacao Financeira) is targeted towards lower income families, such as those who receive federal income transfer payments, as well as towards the growing middle class. This empowers those with fewer financial resources to make smarter decisions with their money, with a strong focus on investor education. The government is heavily involved with financial education implementation.

FinMango's role. Improving financial education is where fintechs come in. Fintechs such as FinMango, promote financial literacy through programs designed at helping less fortunate individuals. Through the development of an online curriculum focused on financial education Fintechs such as FinMango can partner with local institutions to inform individuals of the benefits and the ways they can access financial services. These programs would be of easy access as they would be available online and therefore would have an extensive reach. This would drastically improve financial inclusion. The policy aims of financial education for financial inclusion are typically to strengthen an emergent financial service sector or to provide consumers with the protection and skills they need to operate within the existing financial market in a way that promotes their own financial well-being and opportunities (Atkinson, 2013).

What exactly makes FinMango's program different? The program developed by FinMango, besides being digitized and avoiding esoteric vocabulary, will be directed towards low income individuals. Most effective financial programs are directed towards medium to high income individuals as they come from private for-profit initiatives. Public programs such as ENEF and the central bank financial education program in Brazil for example, are taught at schools. The problem is that those already active in the labor market do not go to school, and are usually the ones who need access credit and are propense to indebtedness. Moreover, in Latin America, the reality is that several children in low income households have to work to support their families and suffer from a lack of education, meaning the programs taught in school would not reach them. FinMango's program, however, would be designed to be of easy access and tackle these issues. The problem we would face, however, is how to incentivize people to take time to learn about finance. The incentive proposed by FinMango's program will be **the provision of a certificate issued by FinMango once the program is completed. This moves us into our**

next solution, which is intertwined to this one, given that the certificate will be used to facilitate access to credit with financial institutions.

- **Partnerships**

Another solution that has been discussed is the possibility of a private-public partnership. According to Carlos Andrés Cordova, adjunct professor at the Universidad San Francisco de Quito, Countries like Argentina do not have sufficient help from the government. He explains that "in Argentina, they are over-reliant on the private sector and the market forces. They are leaving to private companies to offer these kinds of services [financial inclusion], but the private sector is moved by profits. As long as they don't have one, they will take a lot of time to get into those segments of the population. So I think the problem is there is not a combined policy, or combined efforts between the private and public sector to deliver those services." Thus, what Mr.Cordova advocates is for the public sector to cooperate with the private sector by creating policies that favor an economic environment where private institutions will be encouraged to provide the public with easier access to financial instruments. Mr.Cordova uses Argentina as an example of this interaction between both sectors. The country used to rely heavily on the private sector, and while this did promote change, it did not at a sufficient pace to help Argentina improve. The country, which was once an economic powerhouse comparable to European states, lagged behind other South American countries in part due to the lack of a partnership between sectors. Recently, however, they have established a partnership. Mr. Cordova points out how the central bank has implemented policies that allow private financial institutions to create digital wallets. Play Digital, a new company made up of public and state banks to provide digital financial services in Argentina, is an example of an e-wallet being created through the joint venture of private and public institutions. Other e-wallets such as the one by Fintech Ohana and MODO, jointly launched by more than 30 banks, have also been developed with the intent of competing with MercadoPago, Mercado Libre's digital wallet. These e-wallets have been developed thanks to a public initiative in partnership with the private sector, developing policies that enable banks to compete with MercadoLibre, the biggest company in Latin America in the NYSE. Through more e-wallet, fomented by the desire to compete, people have more access to financial services. The reach of digital wallets increases with greater variety, and competition promotes quality and ease of access. Consequently, you have more people included in financial services. This is one example of how public and private partnerships allow for greater financial inclusion. Mr. Cordova believes that "this combination of policies, this creation of new products for competition makes it accessible for some companies to make these [financial] products available for the masses" **Essentially, partnerships are about increasing the array of financial products that can be offered to a population, making them either with the public, the private or a combination of both sectors.**

- **Access to Credit**

The third solution would be improving access to credit. As discussed before, credit is extremely important for participation in the financial system. The most excluded portion of the population in terms of finance are statistically lower income people, who do not have necessary education, access or capital to use financial instruments. In order to allow the use of these instruments,

one of the possibilities is to acquire leverage through loans and the ability to use and access credit. Once again, as concluded in the [previous sections](#), a determining factor in allowing Brazil to exceed Argentina in terms of financial inclusion appeared to be the astonishing difference in terms of credit portfolio for lower and middle-income consumers.

FinMango's role. FinMango's role would be firstly to approximate low cost banks to lower income individuals in Latin America. It would raise awareness regarding online banking services that could be favorable to them, particularly those offering micro financing and microcredit opportunities, which would allow them to obtain leverage to use in financial instruments. The problem with obtaining both credit and loans is that organizations are often reluctant to offer these opportunities to lower income portions of the population. Low income usually signifies that they have low value assets, meaning that they are unable to offer collateral for loans or credit of substantial value which would allow them to obtain these services with low interest rates. Ergo, FinMango would also partner with low cost banks and other microcredit and micro financing institutions to lower interest rates. It would accomplish this through the certificate emitted through its financial education programme. It would indicate to these banks that the individuals, despite low incomes and inability to provide high value collateral, are financially educated, which reduces risk of default as money management skills increase. This will allow them to obtain loans and credit at lower interests, encouraging them to do so and therefore, engage in the financial system and become financially included through their own initiatives and opportunities we are providing. We are not only helping them access credit but also providing them with an incentive to complete the financial education program, which virtually no other program has in Latin America. Here we will be employing the last two solutions: **partnerships with private and public institutions** to improve access to financial instruments, particularly **access to credit**.

Road Map

Spring 2021	Fall 2021	Spring 2022	Fall 2022
• Build 3 short digital courses on financial education in bigger cities within Brazil & Argentina; find partners to help • Design assessments for each course, including tests/homework • Develop a plan for remote proctoring; seek partners for this effort • Begin talks with financial institutions to seek a pathway for discounting borrowing rates	Identify and partner with accrediting bodies for the certification program	Aim to have at least 1,000 people successfully complete the program and more signing up	Expand and replicate program in Latin America by partnering with other financial institutions

We plan to begin implementation in the main Brazilian cities. The country is the biggest economy in Latin America and will offer a good starting point to measure the success of our

program. As a digitized curriculum requires access to technology, which only percentages in Brazil's most urbanized cities have, we will begin in the bigger cities. As the program becomes effective we will start to implement it in other countries in Latin America, also starting in bigger cities and slowly moving to more rural areas where there is significant access to technology for the program to be explored.

Conclusion

In concluding the report, one could summarize the findings by stating that while, overall, Latin America has faced significant advances in the area of financial inclusion, there is still a disparity between lower classes and the middle and upper classes in terms of access and ability to use financial instruments. Their advances also seem to be extremely dependent on financial scenarios, and due to the economic and political instability in the region, setbacks seem to occur quite often (as seen from 2014 to 2017). Using the analysis of Argentina and Brazil as illustrations of the region, their main challenge still seems to be high levels of inequality and lack of financial literacy, which means main policies need to be able to target lower income portions of the population. While higher income portions of the population seem financially literate and able to use financial instruments and participate in the system, lower income portions of the population seem to face high interest rates and lack of access to low cost institutions which discourage their participation in the system.

The region has expressed, however, that it intends to tackle the issue with recent policies being put into place which are just starting to look effective. However, there are still problems that they are unable to address, particularly finding a way for educational programs to reach lower income portions of the population, who have little incentives to focus on educating themselves financially, given the opportunity cost of spending time educating themselves is their work. That is where FInMango comes in. Its work in financial education can be pivotal towards potentially creating an online curriculum that can be accessible to lower income portions of the population, which is a determining factor in decreasing the wealth and education disparity in Latin America that is the main propeller of the lack of financial inclusion in the region. This program will also be key in helping these individuals obtain lower interests and more opportunities to participate in the financial system.

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